

Explore the Save Mode With FOSS



With the recession clouds only just beginning to recede, FOSS seems the best road to take in order to slash IT costs.

*H*ave you ever gone scuba diving? On surface, the ocean looks like a vast expanse of water, mighty and gorgeous.

Once under water, you discover a paradise of marine life. Free and open source software (FOSS) holds the promise of a similar paradise for companies grappling with the receding recession. At first encounter, you would fall in love with FOSS for the scalability or improvement of the IT infrastructure it promises. But dig deeper and study companies that adopted FOSS, and you'll realise there is only one known-yet-under-rated jewel this software provides: lower costs.

Rahul De, Hewlett-Packard chair professor, Indian Institute of Management, Bangalore, recently released a study on the *Economic Impact of FOSS in India*, involving a sample of 20 organisations—including large corporations, SMEs, government

organisations, educational institutes, NGOs, etc. He estimates India will save around Rs 10,000 crores in 2010 if about half the personal computers sold in India come with free software instead of the proprietary software.

"The cost savings one gets by deploying FOSS are immense. From costs incurred on acquiring and installing software, money spent on complementary software for security, software upgradation costs and switching costs associated with moving from one type of software to another, corporates moving to FOSS saved on all fronts," says De.

Life Insurance Corporation (LIC) of India saved a crore on licensing costs by running around 18,000 desktops on free software, apart from thousands of servers; and the IT@School project of Kerala saved around Rs 49 crores by placing free software on 50,000 desktops in 2800 schools across the state.